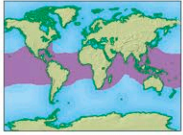


Rhincodon typus

Whale shark



Length 39 ft (12 m), max 66 ft (20 m)
Weight Over 13½ tons (12 tonnes)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location Tropical and temperate waters worldwide



The whale shark is by far the largest fish in the world. However, despite its fearsome appearance, it is quite harmless to humans, and lives almost entirely on plankton, filtering its food with its gills. Its mouth is at the end of its snout—an unusual position for a shark—and although its jaws can be over 3¼ ft (1 m) across, they are armed with the tiniest of teeth. Whale sharks usually feed by cruising slowly near the surface, where they show little alarm at being approached. They have also been reported to feed in a vertical position, using their mouths like giant buckets to trap food. They sometimes gather in large numbers

where plankton is abundant, but they otherwise lead solitary lives. Little is known about their breeding behavior, or about their movements across the world’s tropical seas.

GENTLE GIANT
The largest of all fishes, the whale shark is a slow-moving plankton-feeder. Its blue-green skin is mottled with white spots whose variable pattern can be used to tell individuals apart.

SUCTION FEEDING

In order to feed, the whale shark creates a suction effect by lifting its head, opening its mouth wide, and using powerful throat and gill muscles to suck in dense patches of plankton. The water that pours in is filtered for plankton, fishes, and squid by screens on the shark’s internal gill slits. This method allows for a large intake of prey.





Ginglymostoma cirratum

Nurse shark



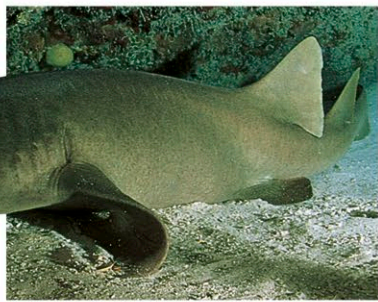
Length 9¾ ft (3 m), max 14 ft (4.3 m)
Weight Over 330 lb (150 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Data deficient

Location E. Pacific, W. and E. Atlantic



The nurse shark has a very tough skin, and a pair of barbels below the mouth for sensing the invertebrates on which it feeds. The small mouth and large pharynx form a powerful suction mechanism, which enables this shark to draw in prey at high speed. During

the day, the nurse shark spends its time resting on the seabed, in rocky crevices, or in caves, where it may be found in groups of several dozen individuals, sometimes lying on top of one another. An inhabitant of shallow, inshore areas, it can “walk” along the seabed using its pectoral fins as limbs. The nurse shark is not generally a threat to people but, if provoked, will hold onto its victim with a bulldoglike tenacity.



Mitsukurina owstoni

Goblin shark



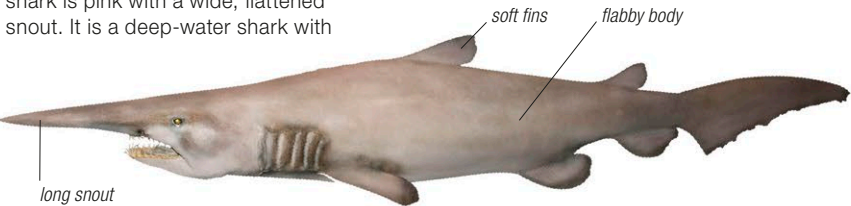
Length 11 ft (3.3 m)
Weight Over 350 lb (160 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic, E. South Atlantic, S. Indian Ocean, W. and E. Pacific



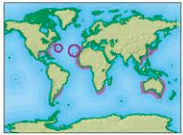
Formally described in 1898, the goblin shark is pink with a wide, flattened snout. It is a deep-water shark with

small eyes, and it uses its large snout to detect the electrical field of its prey. The jaws can be shot forward to catch unsuspecting fish. The goblin shark is the only living member of its family, and it has been referred to as a “living fossil” due to the fact that it has changed relatively little in millions of years. It has been found in the Pacific, Indian, and Atlantic oceans, and is usually found at depths greater than 330 ft (100 m), though depths of 4,300 ft (1,300 m) have been reported.



Carcharias taurus

Sand tiger shark



Length Up to 10 ft (3.2 m) max 13 ft (4 m)
Weight Over 330 lb (150 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Vulnerable

Location W. and E. Atlantic, S. Indian Ocean, W. Pacific



Light brown or beige in color with darker brown blotches distributed randomly over its body and fins, the sand tiger shark also has a distinctive, “snaggle-toothed” appearance.



It is a large, cumbersome-looking fish, with a large mouth. The sand tiger shark swallows air at the surface and retains it in the stomach to regulate buoyancy. A slow, strong swimmer, it feeds upon a variety of bony fishes, as well as on squid, crabs, and lobsters. Groups of sand tigers have been observed working cooperatively to surround schools of prey. The embryos of the sand tiger shark are known to be cannibalistic. After hatching inside the mother, they feed on extra eggs produced by the mother and then on their smaller sibling embryos. Only one embryo survives from each of the 2 uteri.